The Family Scam-Proofing Kit

A 15-minute family plan, the trackers to finish it, and the cards that keep it working when a scary call comes in.

- The 15-minute family meeting, scripted
- Family plan sheet: safe word, call-back rule, payment rule
- Credit freeze tracker for every family member, kids included
- Account lockdown checklist
- The Scam Decoder: 12 scams, 12 tells
- Fridge card and wallet cards for parents
- "It happened" first-hour plan and incident log

Scam Decoded · General education, not legal or financial advice. Contact details and rules checked November 2026; confirm before relying on them. All example messages and numbers are fictional.

START HERE

How to use this kit

Scams win on two things: panic and secrecy. A plan your family makes calmly, in advance, takes both away. You don't need to be good with technology to do any of this.

The 15-minute family meeting

1. **Minutes 0–3: Why we're doing this.** Scammers now clone voices, fake caller ID, and know personal details from data breaches. "It sounded just like you" isn't proof anymore. Nobody here is gullible; these are professionals.
2. **Minutes 3–6: Pick the safe word** (page 3). Say it out loud. Don't text it, post it or write it on the fridge card.
3. **Minutes 6–9: Agree the three rules**: call back, no strange payments, call our trusted person first (page 3).
4. **Minutes 9–12: Walk through the Scam Decoder** (page 6). Ask: "Has anyone had one of these?" Most families have.
5. **Minutes 12–15: Hand out jobs.** Who freezes whose credit this week (page 4), who sets up the fridge card (page 7), who checks Mom and Dad's phone settings (page 5).

> **Tip for adult children:** lead with "help me protect you and the kids", not "you might fall for something". People act on plans they helped make.

What's in here

Page	What	Time
3	Family plan sheet	5 min
4	Credit freeze tracker	10 min per adult
5	Account lockdown checklist	about 1 hour, spread out
6	The Scam Decoder	read once, keep handy
7	Fridge card + wallet cards	print and cut
8	"It happened": the first 60 minutes	read now, use if needed
9	Incident log	use if needed

FILL THIS IN TOGETHER

Our family plan

Keep this page somewhere private (not on the fridge). Everyone in the plan should know every rule.

Rule 1 · Our safe word

Anyone calling or messaging in a panic about money must say it. If they can't, or dodge the question, we hang up and call back. **Pick something not findable online** (not a pet's name, street or school). Don't write the word itself here; write a hint only you'll understand.

Hint: _____ Agreed on (date): _____

Rule 2 · We always call back

Any urgent call or message about money, from "the bank", "the police", "Medicare" or "your grandson": we hang up and call back on a number we already have or look up ourselves. Caller ID can be faked.

Rule 3 · No strange payments, ever

Nobody in this family pays someone who contacted us with **gift cards, wire transfers, payment apps to strangers, cryptocurrency, or cash handed to a courier**. No real agency, bank or company asks for these.

Rule 4 · Call our trusted person first

Before sending money anyone asked for, we call one of these people. Even if we were told to keep it secret. *Especially* then.

Trusted person	Phone	Best time to reach

Rule 5 · Who's in this plan

Name	Phone	Knows the safe word? Has the fridge card?

If someone breaks a rule in a scary moment, no blame. Call the bank, follow page 8, and update the plan together.

DO THIS WEEK

Credit freeze tracker

A freeze stops lenders from pulling a credit report, so nobody can open new accounts in that name. It's free by federal law, doesn't change a credit score, and existing cards keep working.

Person	Equifax	Experian	TransUnion	Innovis	ChexSystems
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

How, for each adult

1. Type each bureau's website yourself (don't click ads or links in messages): **equifax.com**, **experian.com**, **transunion.com**. Look for "credit freeze".
2. Create an account and turn the freeze on. Save the login in a password manager or a safe place, never in email.
3. Bonus: **Innovis** (a smaller fourth bureau) and **ChexSystems** (used for bank accounts) also offer free freezes.
4. Applying for credit later? Ask which bureau the lender uses and lift only that one, for a day or two. Online lifts are processed quickly (by law, within an hour).

For children

A child's clean credit file is valuable to thieves and often goes unchecked for years. Parents and guardians can request a freeze for a child under 16 at each bureau; this usually needs proof of identity for both of you (mailed or uploaded documents). Teens 16+ can request their own.

> **Also free:** your credit reports at **AnnualCreditReport.com** (weekly). Check each report once a year for accounts you don't recognise.

ONE LOCK A NIGHT

Account lockdown checklist

Most account takeovers aren't clever hacking. They're reused passwords and tricked codes. These five locks stop both. Do one a night.

1 · Email first

- [ ] Long, unique password (a short sentence works)
- [ ] Strongest sign-in option turned on (passkey or authenticator app)
- [ ] Recovery phone and email are ours and current
- [ ] Signed out of old devices

2 · Different passwords

- [ ] Password manager installed
- [ ] Bank, email, phone carrier changed first
- [ ] Old reused password retired everywhere

3 · Better than text codes

- [ ] Passkeys turned on where offered
- [ ] Authenticator app for the rest
- [ ] Backup codes printed and stored safely

4 · Lock the phone number

- [ ] Carrier account PIN set (not the phone unlock code)
- [ ] Number lock / port-out protection on, if offered
- [ ] We know: sudden "No service" = call the carrier from another phone

5 · Alerts on everything

- [ ] Transaction alerts on every bank and card
- [ ] New-login alerts on email and bank
- [ ] Alerts go to a phone someone actually checks

Bonus · Devices

- [ ] Automatic updates on (phone, computer, browser)
- [ ] Screen lock on every phone
- [ ] Remote-access apps removed unless we installed them

The one rule that beats most account takeovers: never read a one-time code to anyone who contacted you. Not "the bank", not "support", not a buyer online.

READ ONCE, KEEP HANDY

The Scam Decoder

Twelve scams, the tell that gives each away, and the move that beats it.

Scam	The tell	Your move
Grandchild in trouble	Panic, secrecy, bail or hospital money, maybe a cloned voice	Ask for the safe word. Call them back.
Fake bank fraud team	"Move your money to a safe account" or "send it to yourself"	Hang up. Call the number on your card.
Government imposter	SSA, IRS, Medicare or police threatening arrest; payment by phone	Hang up. Look up the agency's number.
Tech support pop-up	Alarm, "computer infected", a phone number on screen	Don't call. Close or restart. No remote access.
Unpaid toll / package text	Small fee, deadline, a link	Check the real site yourself. Forward to 7726.
Verification code ask	"Read me the code we just sent"	Never. Change that password.
Overpayment check	Check for too much; "send back the difference"	Take the exact amount only.
Task / remote job	Paid to like or rate; then "top up to unlock"	Real jobs never make you pay.
Romance	Never meets or video chats; then an emergency	Never send money to someone you haven't met.
Investment "friend"	Started as a wrong-number text; a crypto app with big gains	Don't invest via anyone you met online.
Bitcoin ATM	Anyone sending you to a kiosk with cash	Hang up. No real agency does this.
Prize or lottery	"Pay taxes or fees to collect"	Real prizes are free to collect.

EVERY SCAM, ONE SHAPE

Rush + secrecy + a strange payment. If you see two of the three, stop and call your trusted person.

PRINT · PUT IT ON THE FRIDGE

Before you send money

- **Hang up and call back** on a number you already have.
- **Ask for our word.** No word, no money.
- **Never pay** with gift cards, wires, payment apps, crypto, or cash to a courier.
- **Never read out a code** that was texted to you.
- **Call** _____ first.

Bank fraud line: _____ Report: ReportFraud.ftc.gov

Wallet cards (cut out)

Stop. Check. Call.

Rushed? Told to keep it secret? Asked for gift cards, wires, crypto or a code? It's a scam. Hang up and call back on a number you look up. Trusted person: _____

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It happened? Do this now.

1. Call the bank on the number on your card. 2. Call the gift card or app company. 3. Change your email password. 4. Report: ReportFraud.ftc.gov

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IF IT HAPPENS

The first 60 minutes

It happens to careful, smart people every day. Shame is what scammers count on to stop you acting. Speed matters more than anything; money can sometimes be stopped if you move fast (not always).

1. **Call your bank or card issuer** on the number on the back of your card. Say "I've been scammed", ask them to stop or reverse the payment and lock the card or account.
2. **Call where the money went.** Gift card: call the card company on the number on the card or its official site; unspent balances can sometimes be frozen. Payment app or wire: contact the app or wire service directly.
3. **Change passwords, email first**, from a device the scammer never touched. Sign out of all devices. If you allowed remote access, disconnect that computer from the internet first.
4. **Freeze your credit** at all three bureaus (page 4) if you shared personal details like your Social Security number.
5. **Report it.** ReportFraud.ftc.gov for scams. IdentityTheft.gov if your identity was used (it builds a recovery plan). ic3.gov for internet crime. Your local police if your bank or insurer asks for a report.
6. **Write everything down** on page 9: names, numbers, dates, amounts, how you paid.

> **Watch for the second scam.** Anyone who contacts you offering to recover your money for a fee, including people claiming to be lawyers, investigators or government agents, is very likely another scammer.

Numbers to fill in now

Who	Phone / website
Main bank fraud line	
Credit card fraud line	
Mobile carrier	
Our trusted person	

USE IF NEEDED

Incident log

Banks, police and the FTC will ask for these details. Write them down while they're fresh.

Date / time	Who contacted us, how	What they said / asked for	Money / info given	Who we told, report #

Our yearly check (put it in the calendar)

- [ ] Everyone still knows the safe word (change it if it leaked)
- [ ] Credit reports checked at AnnualCreditReport.com; freezes still on
- [ ] Fridge card numbers still right
- [ ] Bank and card alerts still reach someone

This kit is general education, not legal, financial or security advice for your specific situation. Laws, company processes and contact details change; confirm them with the organisation before relying on them. © Scam Decoded. For personal and family use; please don't resell.